ZINE

SEPTEMBER 2025 | ISSUE 003

THE ANTI-NOSTALGIA ISSUE

COVER FEATURE: JACK MCVEIGH

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A LETTER FROM ZENE

We are living in an era that encourages constant indulgence in nostalgia - on social media, in movies, and through endless remakes and sequels. Nothing generates clicks, shares, and engagement more than reminding people of a simpler time. In the midst of trying to adapt to rapidly changing technology in the era of AI, nostalgia overload, and advertising overwhelm, we've started to neglect new and innovative human excellence in the arts. Rather than relying on derivative nostalgia, we wanted to highlight artists who bring their own creative perspectives, using modern tools or traditional methods to craft something distinctive. The artists featured in this issue offer unique and meaningful insights into nostalgia, reality, and the state of the world.

- Hayde E.

ZENE, ISSUE 003
FALL 2025

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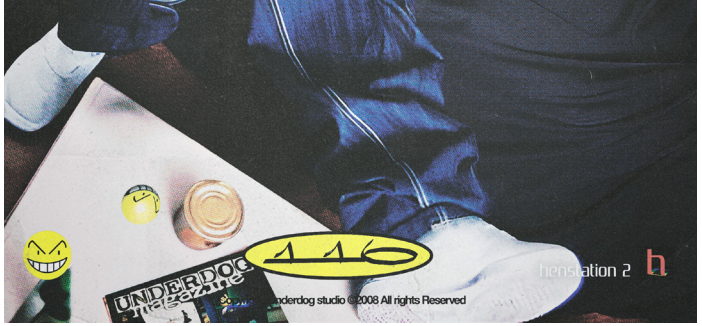
HENRY BROCKINGTON

Henry Brockington is a 17-year-old graphic designer based in Hiram, Georgia. Born and raised in Queens, New York, he is a rising talent who recently launched the first issue of his self-published project, Underdawg Magazine. Inspired by graffiti and print media, Brockington channels the bold, expressive design styles of the 2000s. His mission is to revive the spirit of the 2000s while proving to companies that every underdog deserves a chance.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Who are you?
Being an underdog isn't just about beating the top dawg, — it's about defying expectations, surprising people, and showing that heart, grit, and determination can beat raw power or privilege.
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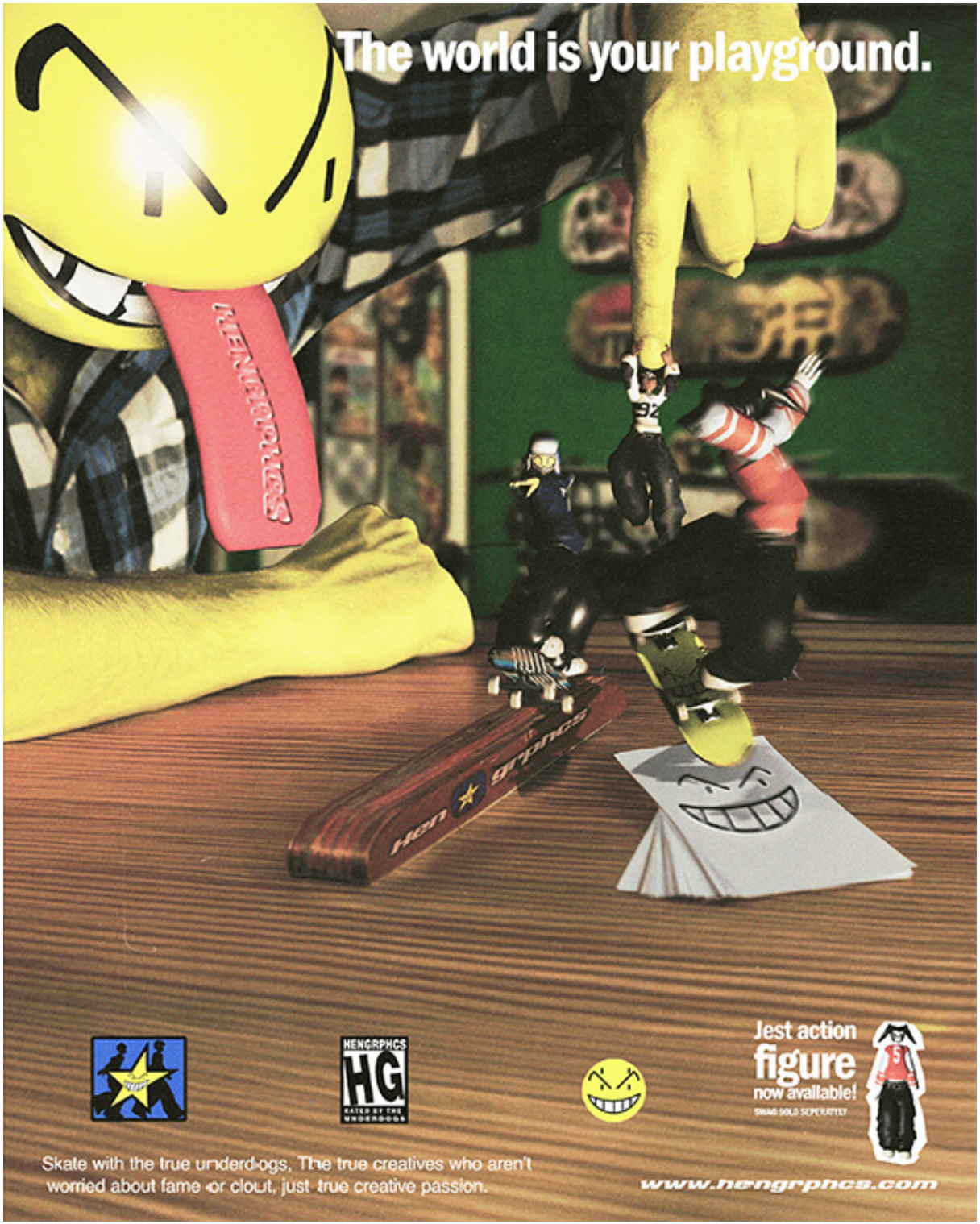
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EXPLORING CARNICULTURE

WRITTEN BY BEC GAUVIN

Carniculture is a contemporary horror simulation game in which the player feeds a rapidly growing plant of mystery origin. The player quickly learns that the 'food' the plant is consuming is a little outside the scope of normal horticultural practices, in a twist ending reminiscent of campy horror movies.

A keen eye can spot the twist off the bat, as the name Carniculture is a portmanteau of the words 'carnivore' and 'horticulture'. The name, in fact, wasn't even among the development team's immediate choices, with picks like 'The Grower', 'Carnivoculture', 'Hungry Hungry Horticulture', and 'Grumbling Gardens' polled as first draft picks. In the end, the mash-up was chosen simply because it sounded best spoken.

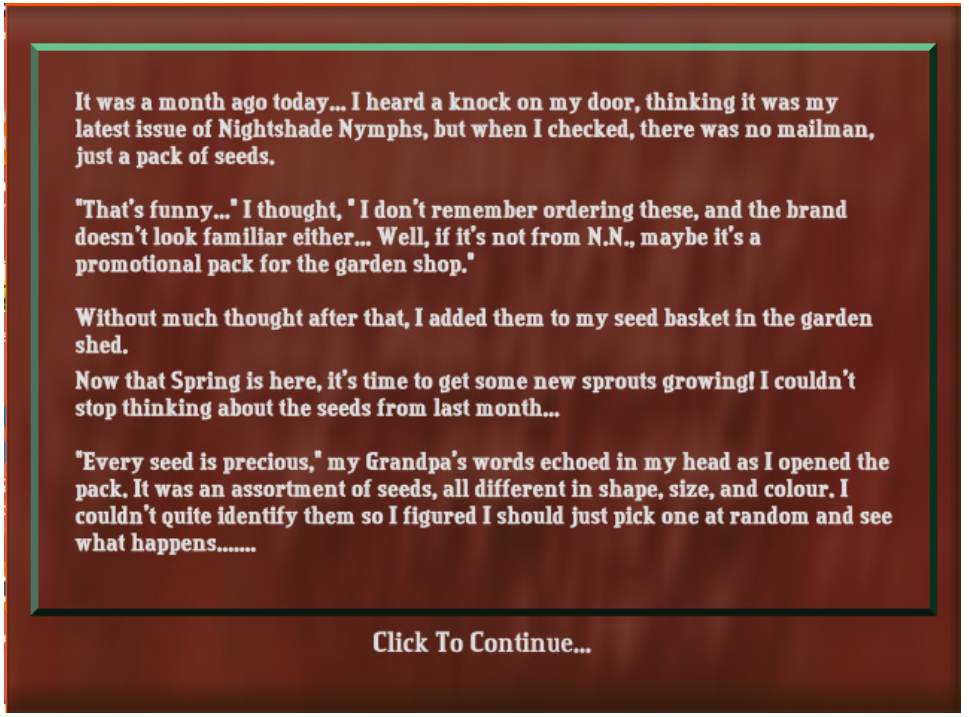
William Estanislao and Fran Carandang created the game as part of the HauntedPS1 Budding Growth Jam (a Twitch-streamed itch.io event where participants make games or content within a time limit). This particular edition of the jam centred on the theme of growth. The pair also had help from Alex Munro with writing and Callum K. with music.

"Although not strictly limited to plants, we decided to go with that theme. Honestly, at first I was thinking of doing something like a beat-em-up type of game, but Fran convinced me of something smaller in scope," explained Estanislao. "We threw ideas around until landing on 'what if we had to take care of a carnivorous plant, and if you don't give it human flesh, he will eat you'", posited Carandang. "Will mentioned an idea for a plant care simulator, which reminded me of one of my [...] favourite games – Plants vs Zombies. I showed him one of their minigames, the 'Zombie Aquarium', [where] if the player doesn't give the zombies enough brains to eat, they die".

The pair also looked to 90's and 00's era pet-care simulators like Nintendogs and Monster Rancher for direction on gameplay. For inspiration on the design of the plant itself, the pair pulled from classic outlandish plant horror (think Little Shop of Horrors).

As for other works, Carandang has created a game for their Master's in Arts Screen Cultures and Curatorial Studies called *A Deep Sea Musical*. "It's a game where you can explore a deep-sea world made of fish-instrument creatures and make them play weird sounds". It can be found on their itch.io @anglerfishing.io. When it comes to Estanislao's other works, he maintains they will remain unreleased because "they are primarily tests rather than something concrete".

The pair, along with some friends, are currently working on a visual novel featuring lesbians.



THE WHITE HOTEL, ANALOG COLLAGE, 9X11"

JULIA DO ALAMO

Julia Do Alamo is a Toronto-based graphic designer and surrealist collage artist, influenced by the Dadaism art movement.

The gritty expression of her work explores nostalgia and the stories embedded in forgotten images.

BLACK SHEEP, ANALOG COLLAGE, 8.5X11"

BRUSHING MY TEETH, ANALOG COLLAGE, 9X9"

JACK MCVEIGH

Jack McVeigh is an artist based in Naarm/Melbourne, Australia. He primarily works with digital media that blends both antiquated and modern technologies, exploring themes surrounding modern behaviour in the digital space and the impact of technology on human perception and identity.

His work seamlessly blends the stillness of traditional paintings with the movement of 3D mediums to create worlds that are digitally surreal and in continuous motion, occupying a space that is almost real, but not quite.

Zene is honoured to feature Jack McVeigh as the cover star for our September 2025 issue. As part of this feature, McVeigh did a quick lightning round: five questions, five answers.

Q: What software do you use?

A: Blender, Marvelous Designer and Unreal Engine.

Q: Has the software or approach you use changed throughout your career?

A: The approach is always evolving, but most of the methods & techniques I use within each program have stayed relatively consistent – Although, for the past year I've been working on a game, so that's involved learning a lot more on the coding side of things.

Q: What is something that has been inspiring you lately?

A: I recently visited an Archaeological Museum in Athens, which was filled with beautiful ceramics & sculptural works that were all thousands of years old. Given how fleeting and rapidly most art forms are consumed nowadays, it was compelling to see objects that had endured so much.

Q: How long does it take to create one of your pieces?

A: Sometimes 3 months, sometimes 3 days.

Q: How do you approach lighting in your animations?

A: Hmmm, well, the lighting is usually old school lightmap baking mixed in with standard raytracing rendering...I enjoy blending the old and the new.

Q + A WITH

RAYMOND PRADO

AN EXCLUSIVE EMAIL INTERVIEW WITH ZENE

From chance opportunities and a lucky streak to establishing a career as a Hollywood artist, Raymond Prado was always meant to be a storyteller.

A storyboard artist and second-unit director, Prado has been a professional in the industry for over 20 years. He's been credited on over 50 film and television projects, such as Stranger Things, X-Men, Practical Magic, Hunger Games: Mockingjay, Parts 1 & 2, Dodgeball, Night at the Museum 3 and many more. Zene had the privilege of speaking with Prado via email for an interview in May of this year to learn more about the experiences and influences that have shaped his work over the years.

Q: WHERE AND HOW DID YOU GET YOUR START?

A: I graduated from Dartmouth in 1989 without a clear direction. I had interviews lined up with ad agencies all over the country, and at one point, I almost landed a job with a toy company in Los Angeles. But when I flew out to interview, something tugged at me — I'd always been curious about filmmaking. I had this itch to be part of that world. So, on a whim, I decided to visit Hollywood.

I didn't know a single person in the business. One day, I just walked onto the Warner Bros. lot. Security was pretty lax back then, and somehow I just wandered in. No plan, no contact — just pure curiosity. I ended up sitting in on a table-reading of Designing Women, which was totally surreal. Then I walked onto another soundstage where they were shooting special effects for a sci-fi movie called Eve of Destruction.

I've always been fascinated by makeup and practical effects, and I got talking with the head effects artist, Chris Biggs. He let me hang around and intern for him — completely unpaid, but I soaked up everything I could. Most importantly, that's where I saw my first set of real, working movie storyboards. The moment I laid eyes on them, something clicked. I knew instantly: That's what I want to do.

This was still fall of '89. I was running out of money, and I turned down the toy company job. Instead, I went on a game show — Win, Lose or Draw — and somehow won enough money to stay in L.A. ***(True story)***.

Around that time, I met someone from the Screen Cartoonists Union who gave me a list of production companies hiring local storyboard artists. I scrambled to put together a portfolio, started knocking on doors, and landed a meeting with Marvel Productions. They were about to start a Saturday morning cartoon based on the rap duo Kid 'n Play. I was young, in tune with hip-hop and dance culture, and — honestly — cheap to hire. I got the job.

That was my first real gig, and I learned a ton from the veteran artists there. When the show wrapped, I had the chance to keep going in animation — Bruce Timm was just getting Batman: The Animated Series off the ground, and I was invited to join.

But around the same time, a first AD I'd met was looking for a storyboard artist for a low-budget feature called One False Move, written and featuring a young Billy Bob Thornton. I met the director, Carl Franklin, and we really connected. Before I knew it, I was in Cotton Plant, Arkansas, storyboarding my first feature film. I've been working ever since.

RAYMOND PRADO
WITH WIFE GESINE BULLOCK-PRADO.

Q: CAN YOU WALK US THROUGH YOUR CREATIVE PROCESS? WHEN STORYBOARDING, DO YOU FOLLOW A SET ROUTINE? DO YOU WORK CHRONOLOGICALLY, OR DO YOU START WITH A SPECIFIC SHOT AND BUILD AROUND IT?

A: I try to stick to a routine as much as possible — it really helps ground the creative process.

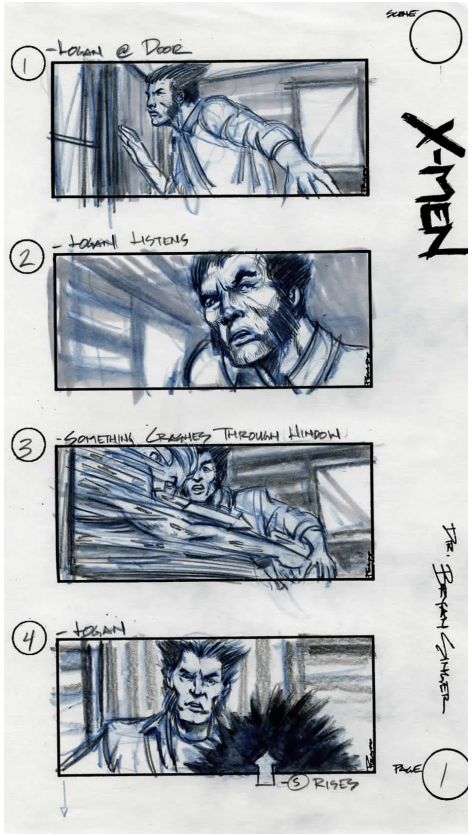
On day one, I focus on gathering as much reference material as I can: concept art, location photos, 3D architectural models, and any available 3D assets from the VFX or Art Department.

I also like to collect photo references of the actors involved; I've always enjoyed capturing likenesses in my boards, and having solid visual references helps with that.

On day two, I deliberately try to relax my mind. Earlier in my career, I had a tendency to rush just to finish the work, but I've learned that giving myself a little space actually allows true creativity to surface.

Sometimes a director provides a shot list; sometimes they don't. Either way, I begin by sketching small thumbnails to explore the scene's flow. Once I have a solid idea, I refine the shot list and move on to larger, looser sketches — this becomes the first draft. That's what I usually share with the director for initial feedback.

From there, I clean up the drawings, tighten the visuals, and render them clearly enough for the rest of the crew to understand. You'd be surprised how often people struggle to interpret storyboards at first glance — so making them legible is part of the job.



STORYBOARD BY RAYMOND PRADO FOR X-MEN (2000).

RAYMOND PRADO ON SET WITH TAYLOR HACKFORD IN NYC.

Q: WHAT TOOLS DO YOU USE IN YOUR DEVELOPMENT PROCESS TODAY? HOW HAVE THEY CHANGED SINCE YOU STARTED IN THE 1980S, AND HOW HAS THAT EVOLUTION INFLUENCED YOUR WORK?

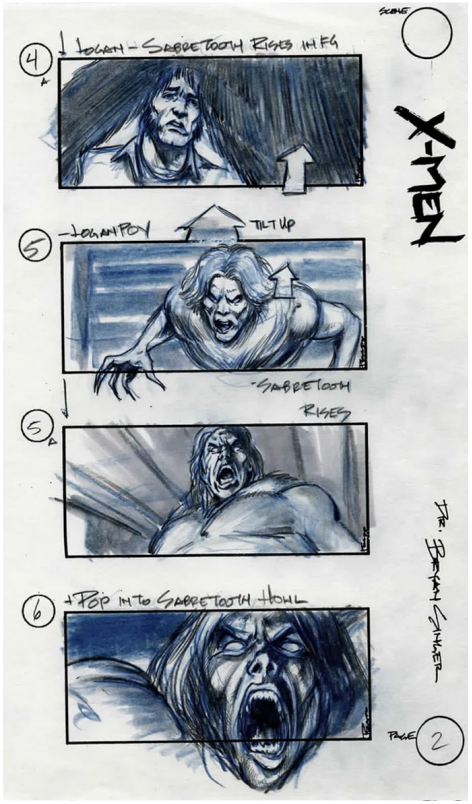
A: My process has always evolved alongside whatever technology I could get my hands on — but no matter how digital things get, the heart of it is still drawing by hand. When I started out in the early '90s, it was just paper and pencil. That was it. The biggest daily challenge wasn't the drawing itself — it was the copying. I spent way too many late nights at a 24-hour copy shop on Sunset and Vine, feeding stacks of drawings into the best black-and-white copier I could find. Color copies were around, but they were expensive and not widely used. This was the prehistoric era of pre-computer, pre-internet, pre-anything. I still joke that I must have inhaled a lifetime supply of toner fumes back then.

By the late '90s, art departments started getting decent color copiers, which felt like a huge leap forward. But even then, once my boards left the art department and went into production, they were usually photocopied onto thin office paper by whatever machine was lying around. It wasn't exactly ideal for conveying nuance.

For large-format work, I'd draw big charcoal pieces on vellum and make blueprint copies — then hand-color them, rework them, scan them. Everything was labor-intensive. It was creative, sure — but also physically exhausting.

The big turning point came around 2001 when Wacom released the first Cintiq tablet.

My sister-in law — who's a movie star and producer — gave me one as a gift, and it completely changed how I worked. I've used a Cintiq ever since. These days, I draw directly into Photoshop, using layers, custom brushes, and filters that let me experiment freely. It's still all hand-drawn — but now I can zoom in, undo, adjust lighting, and tweak a frame without having to start from scratch. And best of all, when it comes time to share the boards, they're clean, crisp, and easy to distribute digitally without losing any detail. No more toner dust!



STORYBOARD BY RAYMOND PRADO FOR X-MEN (2000).

Another huge benefit of technology is how easily I can integrate 3D assets into the work. I've never loved drawing cars or hard-surface props by hand — so now I use programs like Maya, Blender, Daz3D, SketchUp, and Rhino to build accurate set pieces or props. That's especially helpful when a set hasn't been built yet, or when we're dealing with complex action.

A great example is when I worked with Steven Spielberg on West Side Story. I had to storyboard some really intricate musical sequences — tons of dancers, elaborate set architecture, and choreography that was constantly evolving. To keep up, I built 3D models of the sets and even posed 3D dancers inside them as reference. It saved time and helped me keep things consistent through all the revisions.
But even with all that digital power, the core of my work is still the drawing. Technology makes some things faster — copying, revising, sharing — but the hand, the eye, and the storytelling instincts? Those still do the heavy lifting.

Q: HOW OFTEN DO YOUR STORYBOARDS TRANSLATE EXACTLY TO THE FINAL FILM, SHOT-FOR-SHOT? HOW CLOSELY DOES YOUR WORK TYPICALLY MATCH THE FILMED VERSION?

A: Most of the time, my boards end up pretty close to what you see in the final film — but not always shot-for-shot. And honestly, I don't expect them to be. Storyboards are a roadmap, not a rulebook. They're meant to guide the production, not lock it into a rigid plan. What people don't always realize is that storyboards often align more closely with editing than with cinematography. Continuity, rhythm, pacing, and clarity of action — that's where storyboards really shine.

They help ensure that when all the footage comes in, the editor has what they need to cut the sequence together seamlessly. It's not just about cool shots — it's about making sure the pieces actually fit.

Directors are juggling so much during a shoot — creative decisions, time pressure, problem solving, crew questions, performance notes. I've seen plenty of them glance at the boards during a hectic day just to ground themselves — "Right, this is the essential moment we can't miss."

Often, the boards are printed large and posted near the monitors, and as we go through the day, shots get checked off one by one, like a visual to-do list.

STORYBOARD EXERPT BY RAYMOND PRADO FOR THE LOST CITY (2022).

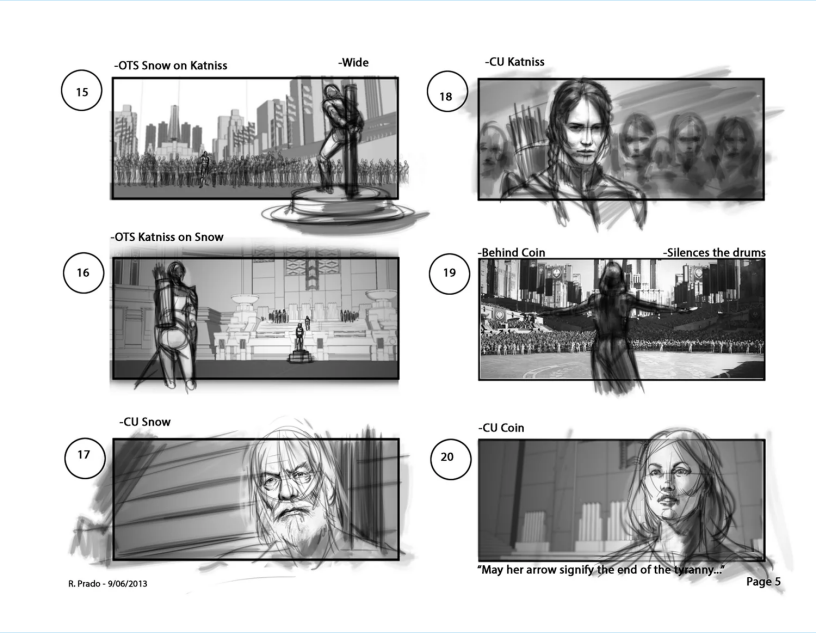
It helps everyone prioritize when time is running out — which is always.

And while I hope that every phase improves on the one before it — from script to storyboard to shoot to cut — there's a quiet victory in just seeing a sequence make it all the way through intact. It's a miracle movies get made at all, much less work out, much less turn out good. So when something I've boarded lands exactly right on screen? ***That's magic.***

Q: WHAT PROJECT WOULD YOU SAY SOLIDIFIED YOUR PERSPECTIVE OF YOURSELF AS AN ESTABLISHED PROFESSIONAL ARTIST? WHEN WAS YOUR "I MADE IT" MOMENT?

A: The second feature I ever worked on was BLOOD IN BLOOD OUT: Bound by Honor, directed and produced by Taylor Hackford. That project was a turning point for me. Taylor was generous with his time and knowledge, and we really clicked creatively. He became an important mentor — and we ended up working together on several more films after that, including Dolores Claiborne, Proof of Life, and Ray. Ray was especially meaningful. Taylor asked me to serve as the second-unit director on that film, which was a huge leap of trust and responsibility. I worked with a tiny skeleton crew — just me, cinematographer Lukasz Jogałła, and whoever we could borrow from the main unit — to shoot everything from montage material to inserts and atmospheric establishing shots.

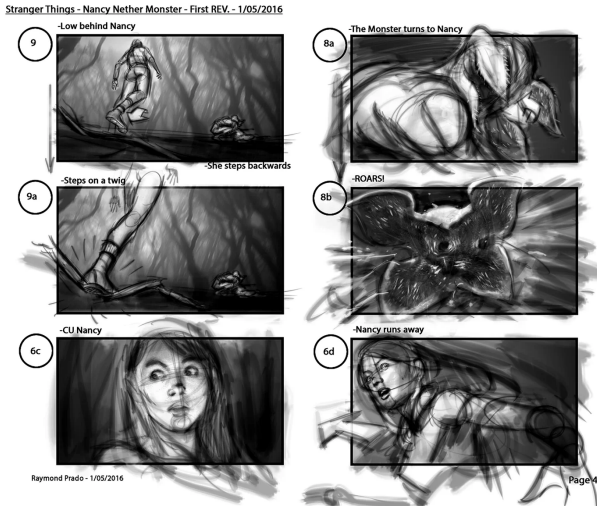
It was a crash course in storytelling under pressure, and I loved every second of it. When Ray went on to be nominated for multiple Oscars, including Best Director and Best Picture, I felt proud — not because it was some red-carpet "I made it" moment, but because I'd been given a chance to contribute creatively to something that really mattered. That meant everything to me. Taylor was nominated for best director by the DGA (Directors' Guild), and the directing team, including myself, were all recognized. What a time.
I don't know if I've ever truly felt like I've "made it" — and maybe that's a good thing. But being part of that film, and building an ongoing collaboration with a director I admire, made me feel like I was exactly where I was supposed to be.



STORYBOARD BY RAYMOND PRADO FOR THE HUNGER GAMES: MOCKINGJAY PT. 2 (2015).

Q: WHAT WOULD YOU SAY TO SOMEONE WHO WANTS TO DO WHAT YOU DO? WHAT'S SOMETHING YOU WISH YOU KNEW WHEN YOU WERE JUST STARTING?

A: The gigs aren't what they used to be. I used to sign onto a show and be on for months at a time — embedded with the team, building sequences, shaping the visual language of the film over time. These days, more often than not, I'm brought in for a scene here, a sequence there. No clear end date, no long commitment. And honestly, I've never known what I'd be doing from one week to the next. That level of uncertainty is terrifying for most people — but I've been lucky, lucky, lucky.



STORY BOARD BY RAYMOND PRADO FOR STRANGER THINGS (2016).

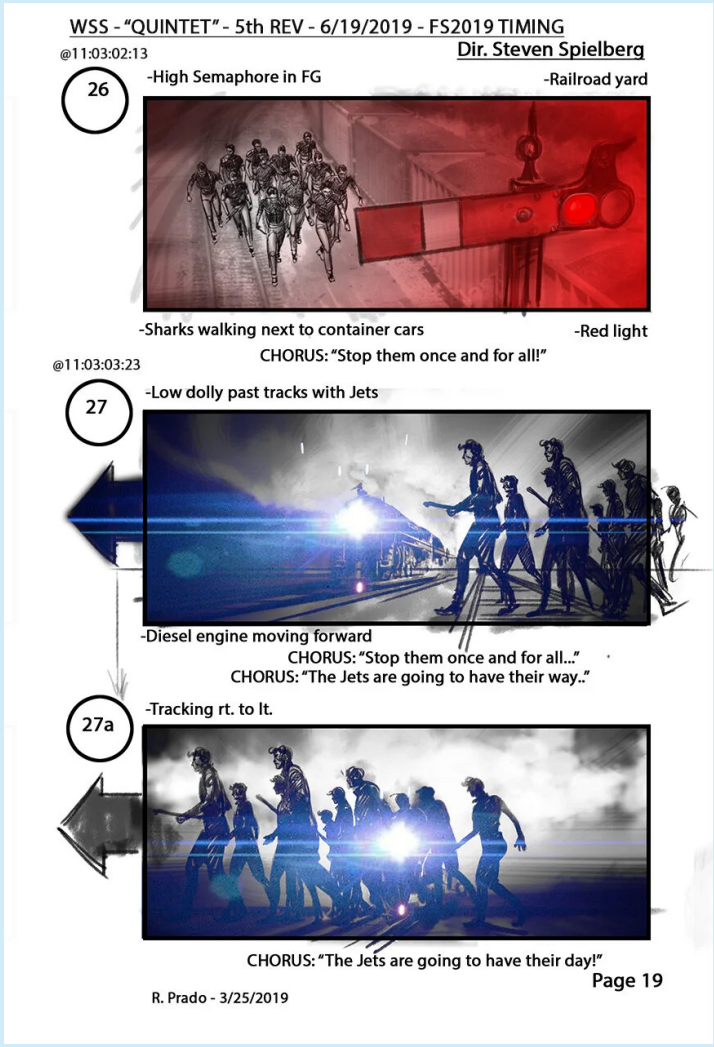
When younger artists used to ask how to break in, I'd say: just show up. Be where the work is. Be around. But now? I'm not even sure where "around" is anymore. The system has shifted so much. AI and computer-generated previs are getting faster and cheaper, and I have a real, deep worry about what's going to happen to commercial artists like myself. Drawing storyboards at a high level is hard — mentally, physically, creatively draining. It takes years to build the skill and speed. And yet, it feels like a dying discipline. It reminds me of what happened to illustration, in general.

When I was a kid, I was obsessed with the illustrations in Sports Illustrated, paperback covers, album art, movie posters. Artists like Walt Spitzmiller, Norman Rockwell, Robert McGinnis, Bernie Fuchs — they created entire worlds with style and soul. That kind of visual storytelling eventually gave way to photography. Now I wonder if storyboarding is headed the same way — pushed aside by automation. But even with all that said, there's still something undeniable about an idea going straight from brain to hand. No plugins, no processing time — just a pencil moving across paper. That immediacy is still the fastest and most human way to get a visual idea across. And I don't think that spark can be replicated by software, at least not in any meaningful way.

I do see opportunities for artists to make things on their own terms, outside of the old systems. But let's not kid ourselves — it's hard. It takes grit. You have to love it more than it loves you back. And if you do? Then, maybe, that's enough to keep going.

Q: WHAT ARE YOU WORKING ON NOW?

A: I just wrapped the upcoming Fantastic Four movie and the final season of Stranger Things. I am currently working with Errol Morris on a new documentary.

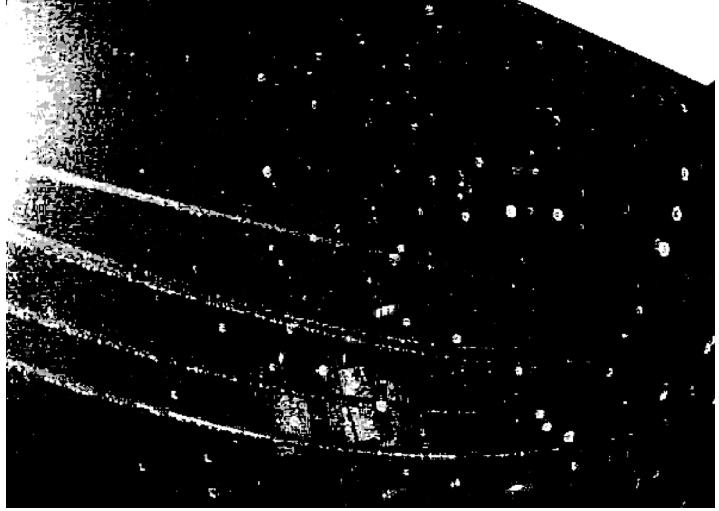


STORYBOARD BY RAYMOND PRADO FOR WEST SIDE STORY (2021).

Q+A WITH

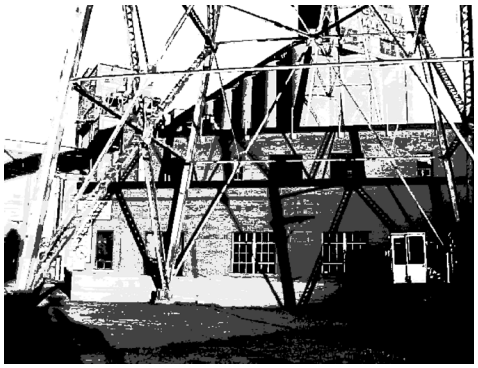
RAYMOND PRADO

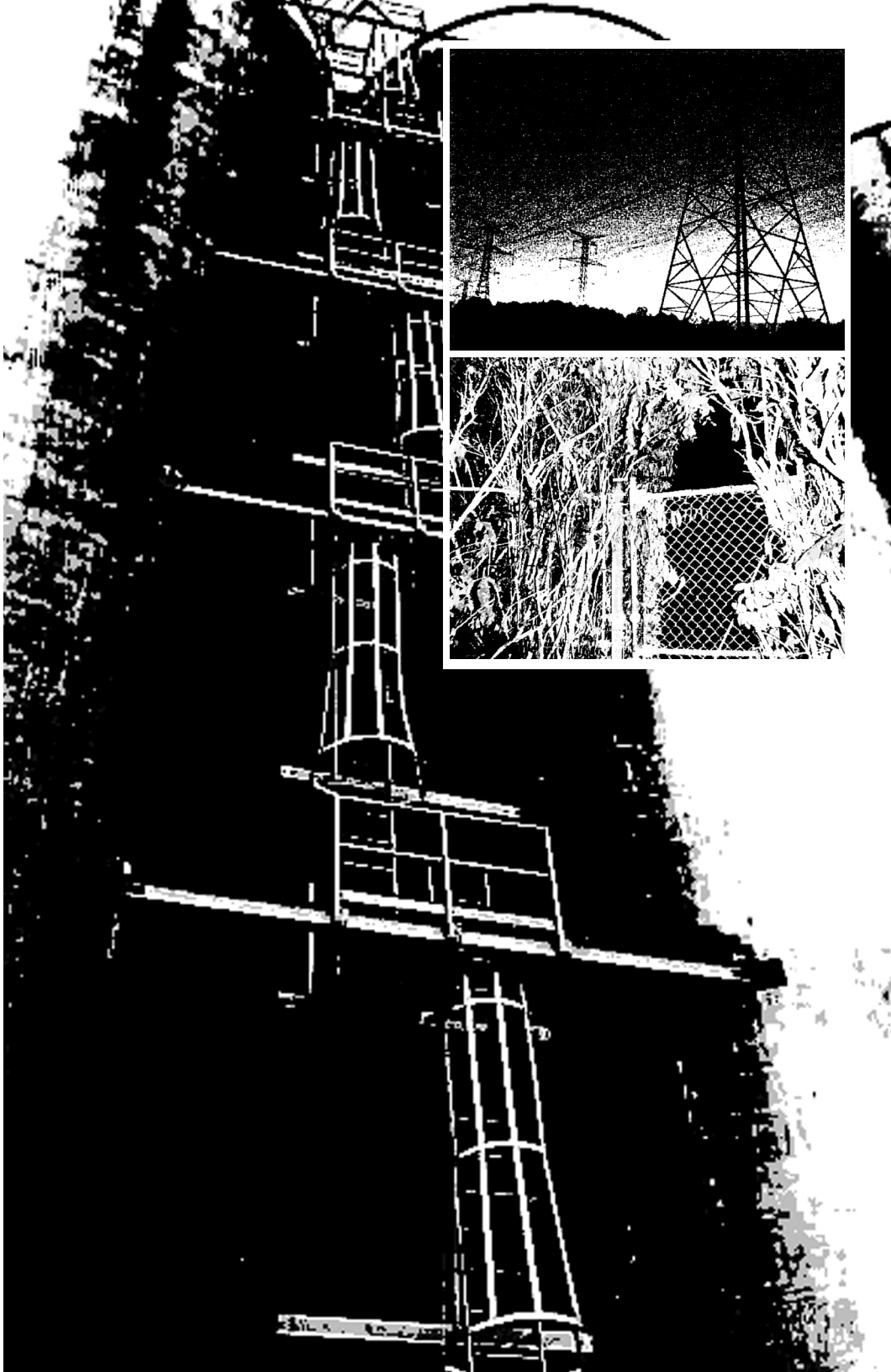
AN EXCLUSIVE EMAIL INTERVIEW WITH ZENE



VERNON KEIGAN

Vernon Keigan, also known as Cruelest Creature, is a digital editor who collages using old-fashioned photo editing software. To match their passé approach to digital art, they utilize older digital cameras, allowing their methods to echo the mood and imagery that inspires them. The featured images are taken on a Sony Mavica, an early version of a consumer-grade digital camera. Trapped in 1998, the camera captures low-resolution images that Keigan further compresses, producing unsettling yet captivating dark stills.





TAYLOR
ELISE COLIMORE

Taylor Elise Colimore is a multimedia artist and performer from Baltimore, Maryland, who is currently residing in Richmond, Virginia. In 2022, she graduated from Virginia Commonwealth University with a BFA in Kinetic Imaging, with an emphasis in animation, sound, video, and performance art.

Colimore greatly values experimentation and play in her creative practices, creating projects with craft and fibre materials, then further manipulating and enhancing the works digitally.

MIKE DAVIES

A LOCAL PHOTOGRAPHER.

He likes cracking knuckles and the smell of gasoline. He dislikes fluffy bath mats and the sound of cutlery clanging against plates.

SLUT
TAXI
A1295

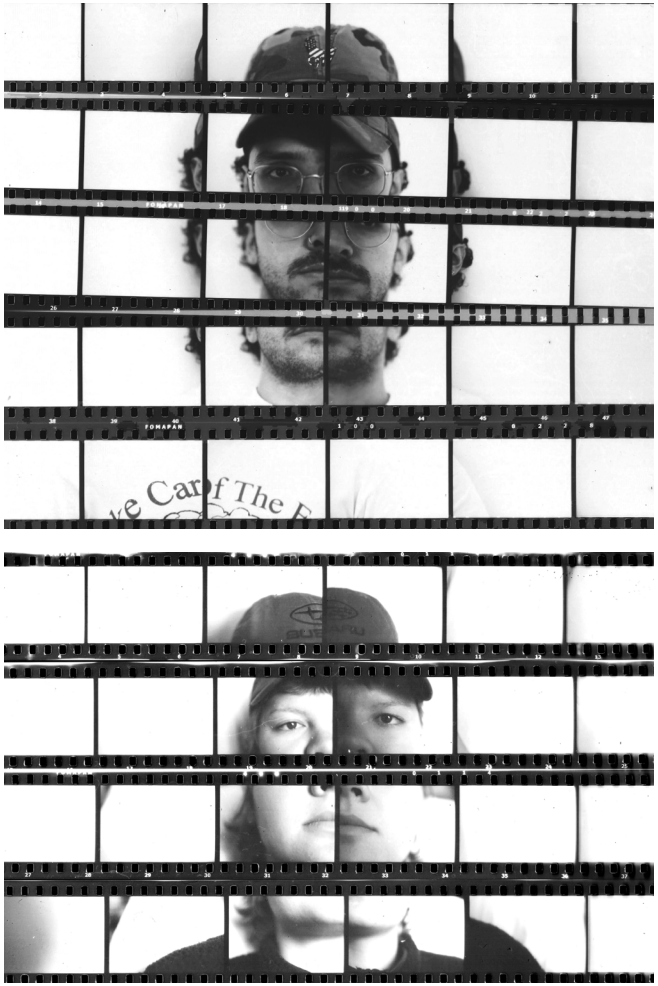
Columbia

CENSORED
ISRAELI MOSSAD EXECUTED 9/11

EVAN PURNEY

Evan Purney is an emerging artist from Halifax, Nova Scotia, who uses photography to reflect and process his emotions. The core themes in his work are the joy of impulsivity and youth, a fear of aging, decay, and the unknown. Purney focuses his lens on people and the traces of existence they leave behind in everyday life – this is captured through a variety of photographic styles: street, portraiture, concert, and still life.

Purney's work has been featured by online publications such as PopPhoto.com, Petapixel, and Lomography. His work has also been exhibited in Halifax Galleries.



Rising and falling with deep breaths,
My senses obstructed.
There are no stars left in the sky.

I feel at peace for the first time in months.
My body dips beneath the surface,
Deeper and deeper I sink,
Currents carrying me to places unknown

I am not afraid.

night 01-13

EQUAL

A band formed, or fated?

WRITTEN BY BEC GAUVIN
PHOTOGRAPHED BY EMMA WARD
MAKEUP BY ALANA HEWITT

Looking at Chelsea and Saleen Nolan, you wouldn't imagine the two had much in common. One sister favours light, playful looks; the other leans into a darker, more alternative style. The Nolan sisters are a striking pair of contrasts. It's the sisters' stark differences that allow the musical duo to work so well, and what binds them in their shared belief that, regardless of culture or creed, everyone should be treated equally.

Zene sat down with ***Equal*** to dive deeper into their music, traditions, and dynamic as a duo. ***Equal*** is home-grown to this Durham-based magazine, coming from Oshawa, Ontario themselves.

The sisters are close in age, with 25-year-old Chelsea just a couple of years older than 23-year-old Saleen.

They've been singing together their whole lives, but began harmonizing and writing songs in earnest around ages 12 and 10. "Our dad really encouraged us to do what we loved," Saleen recalls. "He got us started early because we knew what we wanted, and he was all for helping us chase our dreams. It's just what we've always loved, and he showed us that anyone, from anywhere, can achieve anything if they put their mind to it".

Early on, the two were influenced by artists like Taylor Swift and Lennon and Maisy (more Oshawa natives, to note) with strong country and folk roots.

“[We were just] two little girls singing indie/pop music. I love that we started young because we’ve had over a decade to grow and find who we are and who ***Equal*** is”, states Saleen. “I like to think we’ve started to create our own sound. Every song we write, it just gets more and more ‘us’ to me”.

CHELSEA NOLAN

The two would perform covers, gradually adding songs that Chelsea began writing. Around 2020, their music shifted towards indie-pop, inspired by bands like The 1975, Valley, and COIN.

Nowadays, the duo are harder to define sonically, blending genres and pulling inspiration from all around them as they experience new music and develop new tastes.

We at ***Zene*** still hear the indie-pop influences, with their newer music overlapping folk, pop, and even a bit of alternative rock.

Saleen often takes the lower and stronger melodic line, while Chelsea comes in with an airy harmony layered on top, reminiscent of bands like First Aid Kit.

The pair have expanded their writing horizons as of late, with Chelsea explaining, ”We’re always trying to create something special that we’ve never heard before.

SALEEN NOLAN

We’re diving into deeper topics that take more internal reflection – a huge part of that is due to life circumstances of growing up in your early to mid twenties”.

Their natural contrast adds to ***Equal***’s complexity as a duo. The sisters draw from each other’s styles and tastes, blending them into their musical and visual aesthetic to create a distinct artistic vision in its own right. Their current aesthetic is all about balance. The sisters liken their differences to yin and yang, one representing dark, the other light.

CHELSEA NOLAN :

“There’s a bond that glues us together before the music that makes collaboration so easy...”

SALEEN NOLAN : **“anyone from anywhere can do anything”**

“ I WOULDN’T WANT TO DO THIS WITH ANYONE ELSE.” — SALEEN NOLAN

EQUAL A BAND FORMED OR FATED?

"We play with red/blue, or different shades of the same colours [...] while still staying true to our individual styles", says Chelsea. The idea is that the world would not work without both light and dark, just as ***Equal*** wouldn't work without the contributions of both sisters.

It's said you shouldn't mix family and business, but for ***Equal***, the heart of their music is in their connection and family bond.

"We could never think of another bandmate. There's a bond that glues us together [beyond] the music, [which] makes collaboration so easy. We're able to push each other's boundaries to create something great," explains Chelsea. As for infighting (à la Fleetwood Mac?), the duo bicker, but admit it's never for long, and they generally get along well.

"Being in the music industry can be stressful, but it's also the release we all look forward to, and I am so grateful I get to experience that with my sister and have these moments with her. [...] I wouldn't want to do this with anyone else", says Saleen.

As for future projects, ***Equal*** are working on developing new music at the moment. "This next EP will surely be a level deeper than what we've written about in the past. [It explores] change, our struggles to stay afloat in a world that acts as an anchor, [and] how we adapt and grow for the better. It's an acknowledgment of experiences we haven't fully processed, including our father's passing in 2020. But it is also part of our newest goal in music: to enjoy it again, to find out how we can create as an outlet rather than for the content machine."

Equal released their EP ***Parallel*** in February 2025.

EQUAL: ZINE 003

ABOUT THE PHOTOGRAPHER

NAME Emma Ward IG: @_emma_ward

AGE 27 LOCATION Newcastle, ON

WHAT I DO

I'm a designer, photographer, and storyteller.

MY CREATIVE APPROACH

Focused on creating work that feels honest, intentional, and visually compelling.

WHAT I LOVE

Exploring new ways to bring ideas to life. The process of shaping something that truly connects with people.

Emma Ward
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dinner is served

i lie on the table
face up
plucked, smooth and
ripe
‘you’re beautiful’
the first says as she takes a chunk from my thigh with a brand
new carving fork
‘thank you’
i say as my blood stains the tablecloth
(i never cared for anyway)
‘you’re tough’
the second says as he removes my third rib
(the one i can do without)
‘i’m sorry’
i say as the exposed pink flesh of my lung shines in the
florescent glow of the obscene overhead light
‘i love you’
the third says as he takes my beating heart (in his loving hand)
‘i love you too’
i say watching him take a bite
with porcelain teeth and hungry eyes
knowing that i will never be whole
never be full
but at least i gave it my all
at least i tried
at least it’s over
at least-
‘we’ll take the rest to go’

nothing sustains me

i’m insatiable
but not in some work hungry useful way
no i just cannot be satisfied
everything filters through
no matter how long it takes
or a secret worm in my stomach
eats it all up
before i can absorb the nutrients of my experiences
they just pass
they are
and then they’re not
but i always am
on a continuous monotonous train
stand back
this train does not stop here
it does not stop anywhere
it will just keep going
until the power runs out

elâ sophia

Elâ Sophia is a 24-year-old British, Turkish, and Cypriot Actor and Writer living on the outskirts of London, England with her partner, Erik, their cat and rabbits.

She is a die-hard nostalgist who simultaneously finds nostalgia physically painful, in addition to being a lover of the bizarre and absurd.

all my lives have merged into one big doughy lump

and it's comforting to squeeze and smell and play with

but after i've prodded and poked it

moulded it into every conceivable shape that it has already

been countless times before

i am bored

so relentlessly bored i want to throw it against a wall

but i don't

and yet i don't throw it away either

i am too attached to it to throw it away but too unhappy with it

to be inclined to pick it up again

so now we're in a stand off

me and the dough

the dough is deforming into more of a puddle now

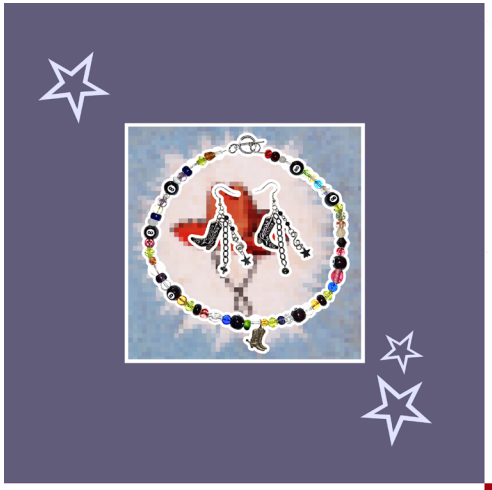
if i could just remember how i used to be able to stop that

but i can't

so i hold my hands around the edges and hope that it is enough

hope
beyond hope
that someday
something
will be more than just enough

elâ sophia



ARTS OR CRAFTS?

THE RESURGENCE OF LOST ARTS AND HOW GEN Z IS FINDING THEIR WAY BACK TO "GRANDMA CRAFTS", BY BEC GAUVIN.

Last week, I told a friend that I was embroidering a present for my partner's mother, to which she replied, "I didn't know you were such a Grandma". This week, I mended her clothes for her because she didn't know how.

Though her comment was meant in jest, it made me realize that for many young people, especially young women, the practical skills once common among our mothers and grandmothers are now often seen as optional or unimportant. So, when did we stop learning how to sew, knit, crochet, embroider, and cross-stitch? Are they all just skills of the past that disinterested generations have discarded?

This writer decided to talk to the coolest 'grandma crafter' she knows to get to the bottom of it all. Brooke Kennedy is a self-taught crochet artist who goes by the name Alchemyarn (that's **@alchemyarn** on Instagram, if you're curious). She creates a variety of textile works, but at Zene, we're especially drawn to her crochet pieces that bridge generations: traditional patterns reminiscent of those on grandma's kitchen table, subtly woven with nods to contemporary pop culture.

To gain a better understanding of the modern textile movement online that is encouraging young people to pick up crochet hooks and knitting needles, Brooke and I had an email conversation about the revival and survival of generational skilled arts.

ALL TEXTILE DESIGNS IN THIS ARTICLE ARE HANDMADE BY BROOKELYNN KENNEDY.

Q: How long have you been crocheting? How did you learn? Was there someone who taught you?

A: I wish I had some awesome story to tell, but truthfully, it was Covid boredom. The first time I attempted to crochet was back around 2016-2017, when a close friend tried to show me a few stitches on a whim. I immediately became frustrated and decided I had no interest in it.

Suddenly, it was 2021, and I was looking for any creative outlet. I bought some yarn and a hook, watched some YouTube videos, and really gave it my best shot. It was slow going, but I haven't stopped since! YouTube is an amazing resource to learn anything your heart desires — you only need patience.

Q: What sparks your creative process? Do you search for new patterns or do you create your own?

A: Most of my process starts with the media I enjoy — video games and internet culture primarily. Making merchandise you wouldn't be able to find elsewhere with your own hands is such a wonderful feeling!

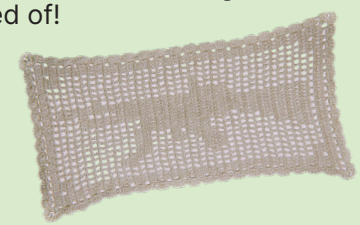
I typically make my own charts for specific endeavours, but being able to follow a pattern and turn your brain off is incredibly therapeutic. Most of my work is a combination of patterns and alterations made to suit my end goal. Even with alterations, it's so important to credit pattern makers. They're an important pillar of the community.

Q: Since crochet styles have cycled back into popularity in the last five or so years, do you think it's brought more attention to crochet artists, or drowned them out with commercial mass production?

A: This is a fantastic question. It's hard to say, but overall, I think it's brought more attention to crochet artists. Certainly more than in years prior. Even with this commercial mass production, it has shed light on the craft as a whole, and there are always people interested in how it's made – and for some, how they can make it themselves. Crochet is also incredibly versatile. A lot of crochet artists have carved out a niche for themselves, which you can't find in mass production. Some great examples are KnottedNeon, AltKnots and Ty_Bailie who focus on specific subject matter to draw in like-minded supporters.

Q: Do you think the recent surge in crochet popularity has sparked increased interest in learning the craft?

A: Absolutely! You can simply look up "crochet" somewhere like YouTube, and the comments are flooded with people sharing their interest in starting. Trends also play a big part in introducing people to crochet, like the filet doily pieces that are booming right now. Being part of a community or feeling like you're in a special club of people sharing the same craft certainly has appeal. That's nothing to be ashamed of!



Q: Do you think crochet and other traditional arts will be reclaimed as something taught generationally, or will they die out altogether?

A: I try not to be cynical, but it's hard to see crochet sticking around as it once did. With the rise of screen time and media at our fingertips, people are no longer looking for ways to cure their boredom. I fear creativity will plummet altogether. It was once true that if you wanted a crochet blanket, someone had to make it. This is no longer true. We can buy mass-produced blankets and hats that replicate the look, and for many, that's good enough. I think this fact will be the largest contributing factor to the dwindling of fibre art. My fingers are crossed that with the help of platforms to share our art, traditional art of all kinds will have a community that lasts. Only time will tell.

Editor's Note:
I've recently discovered that true crochet is inimitable by machines, but there are knitting machines that get a similar look. I feel as though there's a grander allegory there about mass production falling short of the real deal and instead being a hollow, lesser version. I'm sure it's also reassuring to Brooke that AI cannot replace her…Yet.

Q: Is there anything else you'd like to tell us about yourself, your art, or your opinions on trend cycles and generational art?

A: I think it's important to always try new things, indulge, and share your art with anyone who'll pay attention. I've dabbled in every art medium imaginable, and I've felt silly at times for picking up and dropping them so quickly. Ultimately, it's trying new things that leads to finding what you really enjoy. By all means, take part in trends you enjoy, but don't let them control your life.

Often, skills such as sewing, knitting, crocheting, embroidery, and cross-stitch are dismissed as mere hobbies, seemingly to diminish the creator's work. I believe this stems from the fact that these skillful practices have traditionally been learned by women in a world that has long overlooked women's artistry.

This mindset reinforces the notion that such intricate and delicate processes are merely pastimes, rather than art worthy of admiration — so much so that creators in these mediums often downplay their work compared to artists in other disciplines. I also believe that this attitude does a disservice to the warmth, beauty, and nostalgia inherent in these crafts. What used to be commonplace has now become scarce, and it may truly be a case of we won't know what we've got till it's gone.